

“Everyone Thinks They’re Special”: How Schools Teach Children Their Social Station

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Abstract

Sociologists have identified many ways that childhood inequalities promote social reproduction. These inequalities are not always explicitly linked to what children are taught about their position and direction in the world, what I term their social station. Extant case studies find that social station socialization has meritocratic underpinnings (e.g., elite boarding schoolers are taught they are the “best of the best”). But societal changes, including increased emphasis on identity in educational institutions’ and employers’ evaluative practices, raise the prospect of similar changes in childhood socialization. I conducted three years of observations in two racially diverse elementary schools—one upper-middle class, the other working class—supplemented by interviews with 101 students, teachers, and parents. Students were taught markedly different lessons about their social station, but neither school predicated this on meritocratic achievement narratives. Overall, children at the upper-middle-class school were taught to see themselves as always-already special because of their internal qualities. Children at the working-class school were taught to see themselves as conditionally good if they adhered to external rules. Variations were visible for Asian American girls at the upper-middle-class school and poor students and Black students at the working-class school. I discuss the importance of school socialization and the implications of discrimination, identity rhetoric, and individualism for social reproduction.

Keywords

socialization, childhood, schools, inequality, social station

To understand social reproduction, scholars have examined various aspects of childhood inequality. Stratification researchers have highlighted how children from wealthier backgrounds benefit from more resources than their peers (Downey and Condon 2016; Entwisle, Alexander, and Olson 2007; Reardon 2013). Culture and family scholars have demonstrated class differences in learned skills and dispositions, which are unequally rewarded by gatekeepers (Calarco 2018; Larreau 2011; Streib 2011). And sociologists of race and gender have detailed the many ways children of color and girls experience discrimination throughout their formative years

(Gansen 2021; Morris and Perry 2017; Van Ausdale and Feagin 1996). These literatures teach us quite a bit about processes of childhood inequality. However, they do not say much about children’s sense of self, even though there is strong evidence that how adults see themselves has wide-ranging effects

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on their lives (Andersson and Hitlin 2022; Lamont 2019). That is, links between the above literatures and what children are taught about their sense of self are not always explicit.

To be sure, scholars have examined aspects of what children are taught about their position and direction in the world, or as I term it, their *social station*.¹ Recent works emphasize lessons on position in the world, including children's sense of worth or standing relative to peers according to academic ability or material consumption (Hagerman 2018; Musto 2019; Pugh 2009; Tyson 2011). Conversely, classic works emphasize lessons about direction in the world, especially children's class trajectories (Bowles and Gintis 1976; MacLeod 2009; Willis 1977). A handful of school case studies—examining children in elite or substantially deprived institutions—depict socialization pertaining to children's sense of position *and* direction (Bettie 2014; Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Golann 2021; Khan 2010).² This work finds a meritocratic bent to lessons about who they are and where they belong. Elite boarding school students hear constant narratives that they are the “best of the best” and destined for greatness because of their purported hard work and intellectual brilliance (Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010). On the other hand, students in deprived schools are taught that their worth and prospects are imperiled by their alleged failures to successfully learn (Bettie 2014; Golann 2021). Thus, childhood messaging about social station appears to emphasize individualistic stories of achievement, thereby justifying social reproduction. But what if meritocratic achievement were distanced or decoupled from social station socialization? Both socialization and the evaluative criteria used by educational institutions and employers have changed before (Bourdieu 1998; Karabel 2005; Khan 2010). If they did so again, for instance, by deemphasizing narratives of achievement and accentuating issues of identity, what might this mean for children's sense of self, for “distinction” (Bourdieu 1984), and for social reproduction?

Furthering our knowledge of social station socialization is important for understanding and challenging inequality. Research shows that how people see themselves can provide discrepant tools for making sense of their lives, remaining resilient in the face of structural challenges, buffering against stigma and discrimination, and envisioning positive futures (Eggerman and Panter-Brick 2010; Frye 2012; Hall and Lamont 2009; Hojman and Miranda 2018; Kao 2000; Lamont et al. 2016; Tyson 2011). Indeed, Lamont (2019; see also Reay 2005) has called for greater attention to the consequential “narratives” or “scripts of the self” that young people are taught, and which echo throughout their lives.

I examine the broad lessons children receive about their social station. These include whether and on what basis children are taught to see themselves as different or distinctive from others; the extent to which they are taught to feel valuable, legitimate, and important; and the degree of agency and kinds of futures children are encouraged to envision. I highlight inequalities in this social station socialization and how structures of class, race/ethnicity, and gender inform it. To do so, I draw on three years of ethnographic observations in two racially diverse elementary schools: one private and upper-middle class (“Truman Academy”), the other public and working class (“Brighton Elementary”).³ These observations are supplemented by in-depth interviews with 101 students, teachers, and parents.

Observations in elementary schools are particularly suited to researching how children are taught their social station for three reasons. First, elementary schools contain young children whose sense of self is particularly malleable, such that any lessons about social station they internalize are likely to have long-term effects (Bourdieu 1990). Second, elementary schools provide an environment where children experience sustained socialization from a small number of influential adults. Compared to families, school observations have the depressing advantage of capturing racial discrimination within this

socialization. Therefore, schools provide a window into the wide variety of lessons children receive about their station. And third, although surveys and interviews are effective (Pugh 2013; Vaisey 2014), observations are especially helpful for identifying lessons that are unexpected, unrecognized by participants, or hard to verbally express.

I find that Truman Academy and Brighton Elementary teach students markedly different lessons about their social station. At Truman, through everyday aspects of school life, students are taught to see themselves as *always-already special*. This is not predicated on purported hard work and intellectual achievements, but on children's internal qualities. At Brighton, however, everyday practices teach students to see themselves as *conditionally good*. This is, again, not predicated on meritocratic narratives but instead on children's adherence to external rules. Despite some resistance, I find that students show signs of absorbing and enacting these lessons. I also find variations within both schools. At Truman, I show how certain girls, particularly Asian American girls, were disproportionately likely to receive extra socialization, as teachers perceived them as insufficiently adopting the norms associated with being special (e.g., being too quiet or diffident). In addition, I show that the minority of Truman staff from working-class backgrounds resented training upper-middle-class children to see themselves as always-already special. At Brighton, I show that poor students and Black students often had different, more directly discriminatory experiences. Although all Brighton students were taught to see themselves as conditionally good, poor students and Black students were regularly taught that being good was more conditional, more out of reach, for them than others. I conclude by discussing the implications of my findings. These include the crucial role of schools as sites of divergent socialization, and the implications of discrimination, identity rhetoric, and individualism for social reproduction.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Children's Social Station

Scholars have examined childhood inequalities from many angles. But it remains relatively uncommon for these inequalities to be explicitly connected to variations in how children are taught to see themselves. For instance, stratification research rarely delves into how resource disparities shape children's perceptions of their worth or expectations for the future (Downey and Condrón 2016; Entwistle et al. 2007; Reardon 2013). Culture and family sociologists highlighting the skills and dispositions children of different classes use to take on the world pay limited attention to children's understanding of their place and direction in it (Calarco 2018; Lareau 2011; Streib 2011).⁴ Researchers emphasizing non-cognitive skills like "grit" largely overlook the experiences and environments that equip some kids with resilience in the first place (Duckworth et al. 2007; Heckman and Kautz 2012). And race and gender scholars who detail classroom discrimination often postulate, but less commonly examine, how unfolding discrimination in schools shapes children's beliefs they can succeed (Gansen 2021; Morris and Perry 2017; Van Ausdale and Feagin 1996).

To be sure, some research does consider social station socialization (for a defense of the term "socialization," see Guhin, Calarco, and Miller-Idriss 2021). Recent studies highlight specific inequalities in what children are taught about their position, both locally and in the wider world. For example, Tyson's (2011) and Musto's (2019) examinations of raced and gendered tracking show how school experiences shape children's sense of their academic abilities. Pugh (2009) highlights the role of consumption in shaping children's feelings of belonging and status relative to peers. And Hagerman (2018), focusing on choice of schools and neighborhoods, finds that middle-class White children and parents talk of being too "special" to attend low-quality

public schools.⁵ Conversely, classic studies of class reproduction emphasize what children are taught—or presumed to learn—about their direction in the world. Structuralist accounts see a direct correspondence between teenagers’ trajectory into the labor market and teachers’ or parents’ values (Bowles and Gintis 1976; see also Kohn 1969). Other accounts give more room for culture and agency, discussing aspirations and resistance, but similarly find teens’ sense of their direction in the world overshadowed by the looming labor market (MacLeod 2009; Willis 1977).⁶

Scholars outside of sociology have long-studied features related to social station, such as self-efficacy, self-esteem, and self-concept (for overviews, see Gecas 1982, 1989; Zeigler-Hill 2013). Psychologists, relying heavily on laboratory studies, have found these features can be shaped by race/ethnicity (Porter and Washington 1993) and that class produces different “selves” that likely influence us throughout our lives (Argyle 1994; Kraus et al. 2012; Stephens, Markus, and Phillips 2014). Anthropologist Kusserow’s (2004) detailed ethnography of three New York communities shows how parents and teachers convey an array of lessons about position and direction in the world to 4-year-olds. She finds that upper-/middle-class children are taught a “soft individualism” encouraging creativity, distinction, and confidence about the future, whereas poor-to-working-class children are taught a “hard individualism” emphasizing toughness, discipline, and uncertainty. Focusing solely on White preschoolers, however, Kusserow’s (2004; see also Anyon 1980) fruitful study limits insight into how multiple, potentially intersecting, structures inform this socialization (see Choo and Ferree 2010) and the extent to which children absorb and resist these lessons.

A few school case studies provide intersectional accounts of socialization that include lessons on position and direction in the world. Notably, these studies find that social station socialization carries strong meritocratic messages. Where elite boarding schools previously taught their teenage charges to see themselves as distinguished, worthy, and bound for success due to their breeding and

connections, more recently these lessons have become predicated on students’ purported hard work and brilliance (Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010). Some students (especially students of color) reportedly see through these back-slapping lessons. But the vast majority are convinced that hierarchies are fair and they are the “best of the best” because of what they have already done and will continue to achieve (Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010).

In schools serving populations below the poverty line, case studies find that students are taught individualistic narratives that justify social reproduction (Bettie 2014; Golann 2021). Older public school students approaching graduation with few educational or employment opportunities blame themselves for not working hard enough, despite at times recognizing how their school caters to the middle-class minority and marginalizes them (Bettie 2014). Likewise, middle-schoolers in a “no-excuses” charter are taught to yoke their worth and aspirations to their mimicry of dominant academic and cultural behaviors, but through a rigid, disciplinary approach that undercuts these lessons (Golann 2021). Thus, in teaching children their social station, these schools appear to base students’ sense of position and direction on a structural, individualistic narratives of meritocratic achievement. Yet, as society changes and issues including diversity, identity, and wellness are incorporated into schools and workplaces (Berrey 2015; Illouz 2019), potentially re-shaping systems of evaluation (Kirkland and Hansen 2011; Posselt 2016), it is plausible that childhood socialization will shift under the continuing pressures of the powerful seeking to ensure their children’s distinction and social reproduction. Therefore, social station socialization requires explicit re-examination in light of broader societal changes.

The Importance of Social Station for Inequality

Significant amounts of research link aspects of self-perception to inequality and social reproduction. How people see themselves

has been repeatedly shown to influence their actions, outcomes, and long-term trajectories. A substantial body of work from identity theorists argues that identity shapes behavior: individuals develop a vision of themselves and continually strive to bring their actions into alignment with that vision (Blasi 1983; Burke and Stets 2009; Stryker 1980). Others working in the pragmatist tradition (Dewey 1934; Joas 2000) and in cognitive sociology (Vaisey 2009) find that identities are important, future-oriented projects that provide motives for action as we endeavor to realize our imagined, future selves. For instance, studies show that through repeated “assertions of identity” (Frye 2012; see also Kao 2000), individuals can “talk themselves into” (Winchester and Green 2019) pursuing highly unlikely or challenging goals (although with no guarantee of eventual success given prevailing structural conditions). Thus, identities or ideals can serve as “anchors,” promoting or prohibiting certain actions (Frye and Trinitapoli 2015; Miles 2014).

Besides identities, research suggests other ways self-perceptions influence behaviors, outcomes, and inequalities. Poverty obliges individuals to focus on the present to manage everyday instabilities, whereas greater resources afford individuals the security to plan long-term (Atkinson 2013; Mullainathan and Shafir 2013). These classed horizons have been shown to shape economic, education, and health outcomes (Edin and Kefalas 2005; Hecht and Summers 2021; Mani et al. 2013). As working-class and poor individuals grow accustomed to struggling against systems that do not reward their non-dominant or limited capitals (Carter 2003; Granovetter 1973; Lareau 2000), these experiences engender reduced feelings of agency or self-efficacy (Boardman and Robert 2000; Manstead 2018; Wuepper and Lybbert 2017). Low levels of self-efficacy are related to high levels of depression and risky behaviors (Muris 2002; Schwarzer and Luszczynska 2006), which in turn are linked to “deaths of despair,” such as drug overdoses (Case and Deaton 2021; see also Metzl 2019). Again,

this suggests that learned self-perceptions, or aspects of one’s social station, have profound effects on inequality and life outcomes.

High levels of self-worth, self-efficacy, and agency are associated with resilience and the buffering of stigma and discrimination amongst the disadvantaged. Lamont (2000; Lamont et al. 2016) depicts how working-class men and racial/ethnic minorities endure deprivation and marginalization by drawing moral boundaries that boost their sense of self-worth and self-efficacy. As Hughes (1971; see Leidner 1991) observed, laborers make their work tolerable by casting it as glorious. Middle-class Black families in predominantly White environments cultivate feelings of racial pride, worth, and solidarity to insulate against prevailing racism (Banks 2012; Vincent et al. 2013; Wallace 2019; see also Dawson 2020; Monk 2020). However, narratives of worth can also be problematic. Far-right groups promote racialized notions of inherent worth to recruit working-class White individuals (Aho 2016). And for young adults from upper-middle-class families who possess extreme levels of self-belief, such that they refuse to follow basic institutional obligations, this can lead them to drop out of college, be fired, and experience downward mobility (Streib 2020). Thus, extensive research shows that how people see themselves is important for various outcomes. Below, I depict social station socialization in contrasting elementary schools and examine whether meritocratic narratives remain central to these lessons.

METHODS

I conducted three years of ethnographic observations in elementary schools. I spent two years in a private K–8 school, “Truman Academy,” located in a large northeastern city. I carried out a third year of observations in a public 1st to 5th grade school, “Brighton Elementary,” located immediately outside the same city.⁷ In total, 60 children age 9 to 11 were intensively observed across the two schools as members of my “home”

classrooms, with dozens of other students from different classrooms and grades repeatedly observed in various school settings. Observations were supplemented by in-depth, formal interviews with 101 people: 49 parents, 33 students, and 22 teachers/staff.⁸

School Demographics and Selection

Truman is predominantly upper-middle class, and almost 40 percent of Truman students are of color, including Black, Asian, and Latinx students. While definitions vary, I identify students' social class by their parents' educational attainment, occupation, and income. Upper-middle-class children have at least one parent with a graduate degree, a professional job (e.g., doctor, lawyer, architect), and income in the top quintile (\$121,018 in 2016; Semega, Fontenot, and Kollar 2017). Tuition at Truman is approximately \$25,000 a year.⁹ The median household income of Truman-parent interviewees is \$300,000 to \$349,999 per year. A quarter of Truman students receive financial aid, but this ranges from 5 to 100 percent, and recipients who were interviewed were typically middle class.¹⁰ Like others (Calarco 2018; Kohn 1969), I noticed few relevant differences between the middle-class students and their upper-middle-class peers, hence I discuss them collectively. Children's class position was formally determined via parental interviews. Only a couple of interviewed families—and, based on information from teachers, only one or two children per classroom—were below the middle-class threshold. Interviewed Truman families had, on average, two children. Teachers had largely attended high-ranking colleges, and their spouses typically worked in professional occupations. Thus, Truman is an overwhelming upper-middle-class environment.

Brighton is predominantly working-class. Just under half the students are White, the rest are mostly Black, then Asian, with a few Latinx students. Working-class children's parents typically have a high-school diploma, work in blue-collar jobs, and have a household income no higher than \$60,000 a

year. Almost 50 percent of Brighton students qualify for free or reduced-price lunches. Interviewed families skewed slightly middle class, hence the median household income of parents interviewed was \$60,000. Some interviewed families were poor, earning as little as \$20,000 a year and had a parent who did not graduate high-school; other families were lower-middle or even middle class. Discrepancies between middle-class students and their classmates were often apparent. Interviewed Brighton families averaged between three and four children. Brighton teachers had primarily attended local, lower-ranked colleges, were first-generation graduates, and had spouses with blue-collar jobs. Brighton is thus a predominantly working-class environment.

I selected the schools based on their different class profiles and their racially diverse student bodies. Although I cannot say whether my schools are "typical," their demographics match other private schools and working-class public schools in the area. Interviewed substitute teachers at both schools described similar socialization practices at peer institutions. Truman is undoubtedly less elite, and Brighton less deprived, than the schools in relevant case studies (Bettie 2014; Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Golann 2021; Khan 2010). I chose to focus on 4th- and 5th-graders because they are typically highly influenced by teacher messaging (McGrath and Van Bergen 2015), have a sense of their own place within the world, are somewhat aware of the labor market, and can better demonstrate resistance and internalization of socialization than can very young children.

Data Collection and Analysis

Access to each school was aided by university faculty, who introduced me to senior school personnel. Truman combines 4th and 5th grade; 100 students are divided into four classrooms. Each class is led by two teachers. My home classroom, "C4," was run by Mr. Ryan and Ms. Daniels, both of whom are White (all names are pseudonyms). Primarily

located in C4, in my first year I observed a cohort of 4th-graders and a cohort of 5th-graders. My second year, as the former-5th-graders moved up to 6th grade and a new classroom, I remained in C4, observing a new cohort of 4th-graders and continuing observations of the now-5th-graders. Brighton separates each grade, with three 4th-grade classrooms of roughly 20 children, each taught by a lone teacher (all White women). My home classroom, "401," was taught by Ms. Collins.

In both schools, I observed other same-grade classrooms, different grades, and mixed-grade events (e.g., assemblies, sports days) to be sure patterns were not teacher-specific. At Truman, I typically observed two to three times per week for three to four hours. At Brighton, to make up for only one year of observations, I typically observed for full school days (6.5 hours per visit) twice a week. The different calendar durations of observation are the result of delays gaining access to a second school.

Educators were comfortable with my observing without involvement, so I often simply watched class proceedings. However, I also regularly sat with children as they talked and worked, chatting with them. I was introduced to the children as a student who wanted to learn about their lives at school. At Truman I was known as "Peter." At Brighton, staff insisted that "Mr." precede my first or last name, so I was known as "Mr. Peter," to distinguish myself from teachers, who used their surnames.

While observing I took extensive jottings in a notebook, sometimes delaying jottings during sensitive moments. After observing, I typed up fieldnotes as soon as possible. This resulted in almost 3,000 pages of single-spaced notes. These were supplemented by over 1,000 pages of transcriptions derived from formal interviews with 101 respondents. Students selected for formal interview were chiefly drawn from those most intensively observed. Formal teacher/staff interviews included the teachers of my "home" classrooms, senior and junior staff (e.g., principal,

receptionist), substitutes, and teachers from other classrooms and grades. Time constraints prohibited me from interviewing all teachers. Nevertheless, countless informal conversations occurred with these and other teachers/staff during my observations.

Parent and teacher interviews had a median length of roughly 90 minutes. All interviews were recorded and transcribed except two, where participants requested otherwise (extensive notes were written during these exceptions). Fieldnotes and reflections were written after each interview. Parental consent forms were sent home with students from my "home" classrooms toward the end of each school year, with additional forms sent with students from other classrooms in the same grade to cover demographic gaps. These forms gave parents the option to consent to their child being interviewed and the additional option of being interviewed themselves. Children were also given assent forms before interviews began, assuring them they could stop the interview at any moment. Parents were interviewed wherever they preferred (often at home or work), and children were interviewed either during the school day or at home.

I followed an abductive analytical approach (Timmermans and Tavory 2012). I entered the field familiar with prior work on class and culture, intending to focus on how they shaped gender norms. Through the iterative process of writing fieldnotes, re-reading them, conducting further research, and writing extensive analytic memos (Hammersley and Atkinson 2007), my focus shifted. Cultural socialization was consistently prominent and gradually emerged as my primary concern. I constructed data matrices (Miles, Huberman, and Saldana 2013) to aid pattern-recognition and searching for disconfirming evidence. While re-reading my fieldnotes, I used Atlas.ti to code and re-code, punctuating this process with additional analytic memos. Initial coding highlighted similarities between my data and existing work, with codes such as "entitlement," "conformity," and "help-seeking" appearing regularly. Through further reflection and "pushing the data against

Table 1. The Constituent Features of Truman and Brighton Students' Ascribed Social Stations

Features of Social Station	Type of Social Station	
	Always-Already Special	Conditionally Good
Relative identity	Unique – taught to accentuate distinctiveness	Individuals, but with collective obligations
Moral worth	Inherent – affirmed through school experiences	Contingent – temporarily maintained through adherence to rules
Situated Prospects	Agents – in a pliable world, where the future is bright but far away	Participants – in an unyielding world, where the future is uncertain and pressing

existing theories,” I increasingly found misalignments between my findings and existing work (Timmermans and Tavory 2012:179). A key tenet of the abductive approach is the recognition of surprising findings, and creation of theory therefrom. I was surprised by the prominence of social station messaging and its distance from achievement narratives. Thus, secondary coding highlighted themes such as “morality,” “identity,” and “the future.”

ALWAYS-ALREADY SPECIAL OR CONDITIONALLY GOOD

Children at Truman Academy were taught they are *always-already special* and that this stems from their internal qualities.¹¹ Children at Brighton Elementary were taught they are *conditionally good* and that their behavior needs to continually align with external rules.¹² Subvariations in this socialization are discussed below. These lessons were transmitted by a range of school actors (e.g., teachers, principals, support staff) and school practices (e.g., curricula, disciplinary systems, and everyday teacher–student interactions). I focus on three components of social station: *relative identity*, *moral worth*, and *situated prospects* (see Table 1). These were the features relevant to social station about which children received the most consistent and forceful messaging. Relative identity

concerns how individual students were taught to see themselves vis-à-vis their peers; it pertains to feelings of distinction and individuality. Moral worth concerns lessons about one's value, legitimacy, and importance; it pertains to feelings of self-esteem, self-worth, and status. And situated prospects concerns messaging about children's agency and futures; it pertains to feelings of self-efficacy.¹³ These three components are mutually reinforcing. For example, Truman's lessons about uniqueness bolstered messages of inherent worth.

Relative Identity: Truman

Relative identity—how individual students are taught to see themselves vis-à-vis their peers—was frequently raised at Truman. Through various practices, students were encouraged to see themselves as unique. For example, as part of their History curriculum, Truman children learned about the timeline of Ancient Greece. They were then asked to create “Timelines of Me” on long strips of colored paper. These timelines had to feature at least six events, some from before they were born, others from after. Gazing at the final versions pinned to the wall, Mr. Ryan chuckled:

They're great. [The kids] have no idea about what happened before their birth . . . so they just googled big events before their birth-date and mostly came up with tragedies. A

bunch of them put 9/11 on theirs. One even put the Oklahoma City bombing on it!

Rather than dating their timelines with years, the children were encouraged to use their own initials in imitation of “B.C.” (i.e., Before Christ). So Lucy Worthing’s timeline was split into “BLW” (Before Lucy Worthing) and “ALW” (After Lucy Worthing [was born]). This exercise had many educational functions. But it also encouraged the students to chart a history, involving both family and global events, that was distinct and revolved around the children. Each child was positioned as *the* pivotal historical figure, thereby mythologizing their unique individual histories.

Another Truman practice focusing on relative identity was the weekly “Community Meeting” featuring the “Identity Curriculum.” In 4th and 5th grade, this curriculum involved teaching children about gender/sex and race/ethnicity and challenging stereotypes. As part of this, students were repeatedly obliged to consider and discuss their own identities. For example:

Mr. Ryan put a new projection up, which showed a Word document that had to be filled in. The first task said, “I find _____ important to my identity” followed by a list of options that included: “Family, Wealth, Neighborhood, Race/Ethnicity, Nationality” and a couple of others.

After choosing one, the children had to answer questions about how this issue was important to their lives and share answers with a classmate. Quiet pairs were prompted by the teachers into greater discussion. I observed Ethan, struggling for words, tell his fellow White classmate, Julia, that he chose “family” “because without my family I wouldn’t exist.” After a sigh of exasperation at Ethan’s short answer, Julia replied more elaborately, “Race-ethnicity is important to my identity because it kinda influences who I am, and where I live, and what people think I can and can’t do. And people think things about you because of it.” Satisfactory

completion of this task required children to claim one of the options as “important” to them and explain their own personal reasons for why it mattered. As such, while children were formally learning about community and inequality, they were also being taught to construct unique identities.

These lessons were not one-offs. Other “identity projects” (Giddens 1991; see also Takacs 2020) involved conducting surveys about classmates’ gender-identities and building “shrines” to their ancestors featuring tokens of their heritage, such as miniature flags of India. Importantly, the children were not being taught to base their uniqueness on achievement; it was not about excelling according to external metrics of hard work, brilliance, or what they do (cf. Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010). Instead, Truman children were being taught they are unique simply because of their personal, internal qualities, or *who they are*.¹⁴

Seemingly influenced by these messages of uniqueness, older students at Truman, including the 4th- and 5th-graders, struggled to reconcile their individuality with that of others. For instance, group work almost always proved challenging:

Barry explicates his plan for doing the project. Mr. Ryan says it’s a good idea, but adds that Annabelle has a good plan too. . . . Annabelle explains it. “That’s my idea,” states Barry resentfully. Mr. Ryan says the kids should consider both ideas, and then write issues they have with them. But while Mr. Ryan is telling them this, Barry interrupts three times saying, “But I just wanna say . . .” and “Yeah, but first . . .” for which Mr. Ryan sends him to “take-a-break.” Barry does, comes back quickly, . . . and then can’t stop himself but blurt out, “But Mr. Ryan, I wanna say . . .” “Write it down!” reasserts Mr. Ryan, his eyes widening for emphasis.

Barry was far from alone in acting this way. Group work regularly ground to a halt, necessitating extensive mediation by teachers, with each student convinced their idea was the best

or that they were the only student whose ideas were not being sufficiently acknowledged. Similar issues would arise in other situations. For example, after giving the whole class instructions, teachers would ask if there were any questions. Routinely, teachers would answer the question of one student, then be asked the same question again (sometimes repeatedly) by other students who had not been listening. Students' belief in their own uniqueness seemed to crowd out their awareness or interest in others' contributions.

Relative Identity: Brighton

Many school practices at Brighton encouraged children to subsume their individuality within the collective. For example, every day at 9 a.m., the speaker in each classroom would crackle to life and a 5th-grader's voice would begin, "Good morning, Brighton. Please stand for the Pledge of Allegiance." Accordingly, every child would get to their feet, turn to face the U.S. flag, and recite along.¹⁵ Some children were reluctant to interrupt their free school breakfasts, but none dared talk, chew, or remain seated during the ritual. Ms. Collins described one situation where children attempted to resist:

Last year I had three boys who were so bad. Afshar and then two others, Matt and Ben. So Afshar would say, "I can't do this, I can't do that" cos he was Muslim. And the other two would follow him. But then I asked [Afshar's] mom about it and she was like, "He can do those things." So he was just trying to get out of things he didn't want to do. Like he wouldn't stand for the Pledge. He was saying, "Football players are kneeling." But I said, "You're not a football player. You're standing!"

At Brighton, identity claims, via structures like religion, were seen as threats to collective duties. The children who attempted to avoid these obligations—and privilege internal qualities over external (i.e., teachers') rules—were labeled as "bad."

History, at Brighton, fell under the Social Studies curriculum, and likewise encouraged collective scripts while offering minimal grounds for constructing unique relative identities. For 4th-graders, Social Studies was restricted to a portion of the Spring term. Neither teachers nor students showed much enthusiasm for the subject, with Ms. Dawes telling me, "I fell asleep learning about it so they're gonna hate it!" The lessons were fact-based, not personalized. For example, over a few lessons the children were divided into five groups, each designated a race/ethnicity ("American Indians, Latinos, Europeans, African Americans, and Asian Americans") and told to figure out from the textbook the answers to three questions: "Why did they come to America? When did they come? And what did they bring?" Throughout these lessons the children were very disengaged, regardless of whether the group they were assigned aligned with their own race/ethnicity. Indeed, as one teacher told me, "In the practice [test] yesterday [the students] got most of [the answers] wrong. They were writing that the European Americans were the ones who were slaves!" Brighton children were taught to see facets of history and identity as if they were distant social facts, externally relevant as knowledge for tests, but irrelevant for their relative identity and sense of position in the world.¹⁶

This is not to imply that Brighton students were denied any self-expression. Teachers permitted forms of behavioral individuality, but these were incorporated within an ethic of shared obligations. For example, during a "morning share," Ms. Collins told the kids to go around the circle naming their favorite food. The kids, with varying degrees of enthusiasm, all complied until we reached Louise, who came from a middle-class family:

Louise tries to step back and not answer, saying, "Pass. I have too many," as she grins and shakes her head at the impossibility of giving one answer. But Ms. Collins doesn't allow her to be skipped, and says lightly, "Come on, pick one." "I have, like, 3!"

Table 2. Teachers' Presentation of Everyday Disciplinary Practices

	Purpose of Discipline	Structure of Discipline	Format	Record of Misbehavior
Truman	To regain focus	Non-hierarchical	Semi-private	Non-cumulative
Brighton	To punish "bad" or reward "good" behavior	Hierarchical	Public	Cumulative

replies Louise. But Ms. Collins insists, a little more directness in her tone, "Well just pick one of those three." "Mac and cheese," decides Louise, after further deliberation.

Ms. Collins's refusal to allow deviation from the rules—one child, one answer—demonstrates Brighton's collective emphasis. Attempts by students to differentiate themselves from others beyond set limits were publicly labeled by teachers as "inappropriate," threatening collective buy-in.¹⁷

It is worth noting that a very small subset of middle-class students, whose parents had connections to positions of authority (e.g., school governors), would repeatedly attempt to deviate from directions. Teachers often felt unable to sanction these students, but when children were elsewhere (e.g., during lunch), teachers would describe these students to each other as "spoiled" and "brats." This complicates models of teacher–student cultural matching (Bourdieu and Passeron 1990; see Calarco 2020).

Besides this subset, however, Brighton children bore out lessons about collective obligations in many ways. Classrooms worked together to collect items for the local food bank. Students would readily share personal stationery, such as coloring pencils, with peers who did not have any (whereas Truman students were provided with a classroom set, yet often elected to use their own unique pencils). And, while some students at Brighton with personal frictions struggled to collaborate, most happily engaged in group work, reciprocally sharing ideas (e.g., "Your [drawing] is better than mine"; "This is what I have so far"). Pursuing one's unique individual interests did not trump other obligations.

Moral Worth: Truman

Besides relative identity, students at Truman and Brighton also received messages about their moral worth. These two features were mutually supportive, with Truman children's accentuated uniqueness bolstered by messages they are inherently worthy, and Brighton's more collective emphasis was reinforced by lessons about children's contingent value. These discrepant approaches were most clearly and routinely communicated through school discipline and competitive situations.

As Table 2 shows, Truman's everyday disciplinary practices were presented by teachers as tools to regain focus, non-hierarchical, semi-private, and non-cumulative. This was largely borne out in practice. Overall, Truman's disciplinary system sought to affirm students' inherent moral worth, and older students supported this narrative.

The predominant form of discipline used by Truman teachers was "take-a-break." This involved a student having to get up, walk to the take-a-break location (normally a chair at the back of the room), and spend an unspecified amount of time there, before resuming classroom activities. Taking a break was usually teacher-initiated, but students could, and occasionally did, self-initiate. On the second day of the year, Mr. Ryan and Ms. Daniels spent over half-an-hour explaining the process to their students:

Ms. Daniels begins, "So we mentioned 'taking a break' earlier. Sometimes during the day you may just start to feel restless, or stop concentrating, and you can't settle down to doing whatever you're supposed to

be doing. It happens a lot. I know I sometimes just get fed up with doing what I'm supposed to be doing and need to stop for a little bit and collect myself. . . . You're not in trouble, it's not a way for us to tell you we're mad or that you're not doing well. It's just a way for you to go take a little time, think about what's bothering you, and get back into a frame of mind where you can work again."

Ms. Daniels frames take-a-break not as a punishment, but an opportunity to regain focus. Because teachers also need to take-a-break, the process is legitimated and made non-hierarchical. Mr. Ryan elaborated: "When we ask you to take-a-break, we're not going to come to you when you're sat in the chair and ask you what the problem was. That work is on you." After being "asked" to take-a-break, students are then privately responsible for the ensuing self-discipline. Thus, taking a break is presented as non-hierarchical and semi-private.

The teachers completed this presentation by recruiting 5th-graders, as experienced actors in the combined-grade classroom, to share their own expertise:

"So do any of you who've had experience with take-a-break have any suggestions about what works for you?" . . . Seth throws his hand up and . . . begins a bit pompously, "Well one thing I always try to do is ask myself 'What do I need to fix?' And I think about that." Ms. Daniels and Mr. Ryan nod along with this.

Fifth-graders confirmed the teachers' representation of take-a-break, demonstrating buy-in and legitimating the process for the younger students, who listened attentively.

In practice, students almost never "actively" resisted taking a break by refusing to do so (McFarland 2001). Instead, they passively resisted, as I noted while observing a different 4th/5th-grade classroom:

Mr. Ridley also sends Sandra to take-a-break. She walks over, still smirking, and

taps the [take-a-break] set of drawers, before turning back and taking her seat again.

Of the dozens of "take-a-breaks" that happened each day, most barely lasted 15 seconds inclusive of walking there and back. Nevertheless, in two years I saw teachers tell students to take longer breaks less than half-a-dozen times, and the practice remained the default formal sanction for minor misbehavior in every classroom.

This disciplinary system was non-cumulative: teachers did not formally keep track of misbehavior or sanctions. Students would commonly receive repeated "take-a-breaks" during one lesson without further consequence. Calling out, interrupting teachers, and not listening to peers were endemic features of Truman life. The Truman approach appeared to do little to prevent these behaviors. Yet only in exceptionally rare cases of very persistent acting out within a short space of time, or an extreme misdeed (e.g., physical violence), would teachers enact heavier sanctions (e.g., talk to a student outside the classroom or involve senior staff).

Overall, Truman's disciplinary features appeared to have a neutral or even affirmative relation to children's moral worth. I never saw students labeled as "bad." Indeed, direct criticism of students was so rare it could be shocking:

Ms. Daniels asks for someone to help hand out materials. Jessie volunteers excitedly but Ms. Daniels says slightly dismissively, "No you're too slow." The kids react slightly surprised. . . . Ms. Daniels rapidly picks up on the students' half-gasps and Jessie's slumped shoulders and says in a mollifying tone, "I'm not being mean. I'm being direct. We need someone fast to hand these things out." . . . During this, Ms. Daniels has placed a comforting hand on Jessie's back.

The students' gasps at minor criticism suggest they had absorbed messages about being inherently valuable. It also shows that, through their implicit critique of Ms. Daniels, children

agentically maintained the self-affirmative disciplinary system. To soften criticisms, teachers would often pluralize individual students. "You're not being your best self" was a common phrase. This semantic work meant students were never categorically "bad." Truman's disciplinary practices were intended only to correct behavioral blips (i.e., what students do), while affirming, never questioning, children's inherent internal moral qualities (i.e., who they are). As such, the messaging about moral worth contained in Truman's disciplinary system contributed to the general sense of being always-already special.

Competitive situations posed a threat to Truman students' brimming moral worth. Although students' sense of uniqueness was not dependent on narratives of meritocratic achievement, their complete conviction in their inherent moral worth appeared to be sustained through an absence of explicit loss or failure. Indeed, the school and parents took various steps to neutralize overt competition between students. For instance, ranking students in ways that children could compare themselves unfavorably to peers was prohibited. Thus, the school did not typically assign students grades. Likewise, even listing students who personally improved was not allowed. When one P.E. teacher put up a poster congratulating "Gold Award" students who improved on at least five areas of fitness, and "Silver Award" students who improved on four, he received so many complaints from parents angry that their children would feel "left out" that he was forced to take the poster down. When the same teacher obtained school permission to run an internal 4th/5th-grade European handball competition, he had to manage students' intense distress whenever they lost a game. After one memorable match, the majority of the losing team, both boys and girls, were in near-hysterical tears. The P.E. teacher tried to soothe these students:

"Ok, so let's all take a minute to calm down. . . . We need to make sure we show good sportsmanship and accept that this is how it goes sometimes. Sometimes you lose.

. . . You need to accept that this is how it goes, and not just say that they cheated." But Amanda bursts out, "But they were cheating!"

Indeed, a minute later Ms. Daniels summoned the P.E. teacher in an accusatory tone: "Can you come and help deal with this situation?" The P.E. teacher was then obliged to spend 10 minutes talking through the rules with Ms. Daniels and the students, acknowledging the game's imperfections. Ms. Daniels also reaffirmed individual students of their abilities ("Francesca, you've played basketball, right? [Physical play] happens in basketball . . . and I know you can cope ok in that game"). However, any acceptance of losing as a valuable moral lesson was undermined by Mr. Ryan, who concluded the discussion by insisting: "This doesn't matter! It really doesn't. It's just a game. You shouldn't care this much about a game you're playing in P.E. There are more important things. This isn't academics."

Thus, the P.E. teacher's attempts to reward individual students' effort and teach Truman children to accept losing were diluted. The friction between constant lessons about their inherent worth and the experience of losing appeared to greatly distress students, who tried to resolve the tension by reaching for excuses. Ms. Daniels and Mr. Ryan dismissed these excuses, but they impugned the value of the game, along with the challenge it posed to students' always-already special social station. And although Mr. Ryan implied that academics were important, he crucially did not say that being special relied on high achievement or academic distinction. All students were special regardless of academic ability. Or, as Ms. Daniels noted approvingly in her interview, Truman taught students that "there are no losers, we're all winners."

Moral Worth: Brighton

Brighton presented and enacted discipline as a system that punished or rewarded students for being bad or good, and was hierarchical, public, and cumulative (see Table 2).

This system emphasized the contingency of students' moral worth and its dependence on external assessments of behavior. Some students resisted the system, but they nevertheless showed signs of being powerfully influenced by it.

Most teachers I observed used behavioral charts, which served as the primary disciplinary resource in Brighton. Each student's name was written on a clothes-peg (or other moveable item), which was then moved up or down the chart based on "good" or "bad" behavior, not achievement, during the day (for an extended discussion of these charts, see Brownell and Parks 2022).

Ms. Collins's approach was typical of the Brighton system. She used an airplane metaphor in her five-level chart, which she explained to her 4th-graders during the first week of term:

So you're all at "Taxi" right now. That's good. That means you're doing fine. Above that is "Taking Off." That means you're doing very well. And then above that is "Soaring." That means you're doing really excellently. If these were on your reports, they'd be the equivalent of "proven proficiency" and "outstanding." Below "Taxi" are "Downward Spiral" and then "Grounded." If you come in and you're in a bit of a bad mood, and you're being grumpy with everyone all day, then you might get a "Downward Spiral." It's ok to be grumpy sometimes. . . . But if you're grumpy all day and being mean to people, then that's not ok." . . . With this board there are also tickets. So if you finish the day on "Taxi" you're all good. But if you finish the day on "Taking Off" that means you get two tickets, and if you finish on "Soaring" I give you four tickets. However, if you get a "Downward Spiral" then you owe me two tickets. And if you're on "Grounded" then you owe me four tickets.

Ms. Collins made clear that the purpose of the chart was to punish or reward bad or good behavior. The chart is only relevant

for children; Ms. Collins is positioned above the system as its arbiter, and the children are subjects, not experts, in the disciplinary process. This makes the structure hierarchical. The cumulative aspect is reaffirmed through the give-and-take of tickets.¹⁸ Ms. Collins continued:

For "Grounded," last year in the whole year there were probably only four days in which I put people on "Grounded." That's when you're being seriously bad and there's gonna be an email sent home to your parents too.

Here the punishment purpose of Brighton discipline is re-emphasized. Importantly, being "grounded" is not characterized as a behavioral blip or due to an unruly fraction of the self. It is the product of categorically "*being* seriously bad" (emphasis added).

In practice, discipline at Brighton closely mirrored this presentation. The charts were publicly displayed on classroom walls and teachers would announce to the room, "Right, [name], I'm moving your stick down." Students began each day anew at Taxiing and were moved up or down depending on that day's behavior. When students were fined tickets for being bad, Ms. Collins immediately tore them up and dropped them in the trash. This was formally to prevent students fishing them out and re-adding them to their totals. But the eradication of rewards for previous good behavior highlights the contingency of children's moral worth. Moral worth is not inherent. Yesterday's merits do not discount today's failings.

Corresponding with this system, children at Brighton infrequently interrupted, called out, or spoke back to teachers, likely because these behaviors were very sternly sanctioned as "being disrespectful." Children were eager to earn tickets for good behavior, which at the end of the school year were cashed in for prizes purchased by Ms. Collins from the dollar store. But the charts had the potential to exacerbate behavioral issues. As one 1st-grade teacher, who used a green, yellow,

and red traffic-light chart, recounted in an interview:

[The charts] brought more stress and frustration to the children. For example, Shaun [a 1st-grader], 95 percent of the time he would have his breakdown at the end of the day because he would go home with red or yellow and he knew what his consequence was at home so it would set him off. But then I also see benefits to it too because, as a parent, I like to see how they did throughout the day. I don't want to [have to] email the teacher every day. I also want [my children] to be held responsible.

Teachers recognized some drawbacks of the charts, but valued them as ways of communicating with parents, promoting good behavior, and fostering responsibility.

For older students, the behavioral system also seemed to have a telling effect. Some 4th-graders would become privately dismissive and resistant, muttering "I don't care!" when Ms. Collins moved their peg down. But these and other students also disclosed taking teachers' moral judgments to heart. During one recess I chatted with Chantelle. She cheerfully described having been punished by her mom last night, after Ms. Collins sent an email home: "Yeah, I was being bad yesterday." "Oh, what happened?" I asked. "I was talking to Jennifer," admitted Chantelle, still smiling slightly. Chantelle did not dispute Ms. Collins's or her mother's judgment but labeled herself as having been "bad."

Similarly, on one occasion, while out in the corridor with Yusuf, a boy who often forgot his ADHD medication, he was groaning about being hungry, something he said always happened when he forgot his medicine. I asked, "Why do you think you get hungry when not on your meds?" "Probably cos that's the other me that's more real," he said flatly, in an unusually still manner. Struck by this answer, I asked, "Which 'you' do you prefer?" "The meds one, cos [then] I'm good," he said somberly, not looking at me. Here Yusuf spoke of two selves, but unlike

Truman teachers, he did not pluralize himself to marginalize misbehavior, but instead categorized his two parts into one that is "real" and one that can be "good." This suggests the absorption of school-based messaging, where attaining moral worth is contingent on external judgments of behavior.

Given this contingent approach to worth and the emphasis on behavior over achievement, students at Brighton appeared more prepared to accept competition and losing as facts of life that did not undermine their social station. For example, near the end of every year, the Brighton 5th-graders played the teachers in a basketball match:

While all the teachers are smiling and having a good time, they are clearly intent on winning. A few times when both a student and teacher end up with their hands on the ball, they tug and wrestle just like in professional games. . . . Likewise, the teachers do their best to defend shots attempted by students, to intercept students' plays, and take advantage of students' mistakes . . . with Mr. Kline repeatedly going for three points and holding up three fingers proudly while the audience of kids cheer wildly. . . . I jokingly point out to Ms. Collins that, "[Mr. Kline's] looking a little flushed." She nods, "Oh yeah, we never let them win." This proved to be the case today as, when Ms. Collins's class left the gym at 2.35 p.m., the score stood at 75–15.

Despite the drubbing, the game was played in good spirits. Every student in 5th grade, bar two, eagerly took part. And only twice did students grow visibly frustrated; on both occasions the P.E. teacher, Mr. Parker, spoke calmly and encouragingly to the boys for a few seconds. Both appeared placated by this. Unlike Truman children, they did not become petulant.

Thus, Brighton students were taught that their moral worth is dependent on their ongoing adherence to school rules. Students appeared to accept teachers' judgments, categorizing themselves as "bad" when sanctioned and "good" when deemed well-behaved. Moral

worth was not yoked to achievement (or the absence of loss or failure). As such, there appeared to be cognitive room for Brighton students to lose without it disrupting their sense of being conditionally good.

Situated Prospects: Truman

Situated prospects involves children's feelings of agency and "imagined futures" (Frye 2012). It relates to their sense of ongoing self-efficacy. At Truman, children were taught to see themselves as agentic, see the world as pliable, and see the future as bright but far away. These features were buttressed by lessons about students' uniqueness and inherent moral worth (described above), which appeared to reassure the children that a distinctive, valuable path through life would reveal itself. These teachings were conveyed to Truman students through a range of practices. The school motto, Learning for a Limitless Future¹⁹—featured on posters, the school website, and other paraphernalia—set the tone of infinite possibilities. Likewise, during an open house for parents of prospective students, the principal, Ms. Reed, explained the following to a chorus of smiles and nods:

We put the kids at the center of everything . . . we help them build their identity . . . we want kids to have this deep sense of agency. . . . Each class starts the day with morning meetings where they share issues and plans and each class has a social contract. The kids have a crucial voice in that social contract. . . . But they also spend a day a week at [a local nature reserve], where the children learn not only about nature but how to look after it and appreciate it. How to be stewards of our world.

Truman's public messaging emphasized children's agency, ability to shape their surroundings, and long-term possibilities.

These words were backed up by practices. The curriculum was organized so that agency was increasingly amplified. This started, according to 1st-grade teacher Ms. Dean,

with the youngest children being encouraged to write "personal narratives and opinions," which they would share. This was progressively expanded so that, as one 6th-grade teacher elaborated, students conduct "[a] year of in-depth study of identity through looking at Africa. How does land shape identity? How do I shape identity? . . . They have to create their own countries and then create Constitutions for their country." Here children are situated as national leaders (or even benign colonizers), fixing problems. Paralleling the construction of unique relative identities, facets of race and ethnicity are engaged earnestly, but as tools to expand students' sense of agency over a pliable world.

Older students bore out these lessons in their interactions. For example, one morning the 4th/5th-graders were busy responding to the following prompt:

"Yesterday we explored the sights and sounds of the Chinatown neighborhood. . . . Interviews were a big part of the day and although they may have been challenging, getting to talk to members of the community was a huge opportunity. First, think about your interviews and where people were from. We have started a list of countries we heard about." . . . The second paragraph told the kids to journal about the experience, describing the sights, sounds, feelings, smells, etc. of interviewing people from this community.

Mr. Ryan walked past and glanced at Dominic's writing, then smiled and exhaled, moving on. I read over Dominic's shoulder, as discreetly as I could. He had written that at first for the interview "I was a little scared," but two sentences later Dominic concluded that actually it turned out, "I was an expert interviewer!" This trip and writing exercise situate the children as interviewers and cataloguers, not mere observers, of adult members of Chinatown. Again, the children's agency was confirmed, as was a sense of the world as pliable.

As for the future, many of the children came from professional families. But teachers also

frequently referred to children as currently possessing the qualities of professionals:

Ms. Daniels tells the kids matter-of-factly, “Scientists—which is what you are if you choose to think—do this kind of stuff all the time where they think about a question and wonder what they need to know to answer it. If you can do that then you are a scientist.”

By framing the students as already possessing the qualities of professionals, the teachers communicate that futures in these professional realms are readily accessible if they simply “choose” to pursue them.

Regarding the children’s own visions of the future, cultural capital theory might predict that with ample knowledge and skills, Truman children would have elaborate plans. But, in fact, the children were rather vague and undiscerning.²⁰ When asked if they would go to college, almost all replied “Yes” immediately, clearly seeing this as the default experience. But they had no clear thoughts on what to study or where. Dominic confidently asserted that he would either study “at Harvard or Georgia State—cuz [Georgia State’s] where my parents went.” When asked about what future jobs they wanted, by far the most common answer was a shrugged “I dunno.” Children would sometimes appear to pluck jobs from the air:

I ask Lucy, “What do you want to be when you grow up?” She breathily says, “A vet.” I ask Francesca and she says, “Either a vet or a doggy daycare.” Briana says, “A gymnast or a cheerleader.”

But, in asking children repeatedly over the course of my observations, I noticed that their answers were highly changeable. Nevertheless, these vague and variable answers were delivered with a carefree confidence. Truman students were taught to see themselves as agentic, see the world as pliable, and see the future as bright but far away. They appeared to incorporate these lessons into

their developing sense of their position and direction in the world.

Situated Prospects: Brighton

At Brighton, children were taught to see themselves as participants in an unyielding world, where the future is uncertain and pressing. They were not cast as passive or helpless victims, but nor were they prescribed an unlimited sense of control and possibility. Parallel to Truman, Brighton’s messaging on situated prospects (i.e., agency and imagined futures) seemed interrelated with that on relative identity and moral worth, with communal obligations and personal limitations informing their sense of efficacy and trajectory. Lessons were communicated in various ways. One method was the school’s public representations. The school motto, Be Good, Be Friendly, Learn Every Day, recited daily, made no mention of children’s future possibilities but was focused on the present. During an open house at the start of the year, where teachers welcomed families to their new grades, Mr. Carson, the principal, began with a 10-minute speech centered on district and school procedures. He explained how “the district now sees that any more than 10 absences in a year will be considered unexplained,” before stating that communications would now be done electronically as it “saves the district tens of thousands of dollars a year. I know getting access to electronic equipment can sometimes be tough, but it’s the future so we have to do it.” These public representations framed children (and their parents) as participants within a prefixed system, while acknowledging the need to follow rules and weather financial storms.

These representations were backed up by practices. Teachers would routinely remind students of systemic obligations and challenges. Common phrases from teachers included, “You don’t get to do whatever you want!” and “You get what you get, and you don’t complain.” Likewise, when the music teacher, Mr. Tanney, introduced the possibility of renting instruments to play in the school band, he added:

I understand that families can go through tough times and affording an instrument can be difficult. So if that's the case, I can get you one of the [damaged] instruments from the cupboard and we can, um, try to make it work.

While providing a sense of realism and empathy, these words contrast sharply with the unbridled sense of possibility and agency transmitted to Truman children.

The same patterns applied to other parts of the curriculum. When introducing different methods for solving multiplication puzzles, Ms. Collins stated:

We're going to move on today in math to learning different methods for working out multiplication questions. You're gonna like some and dislike some. You're not gonna cry and have a hissy fit if you don't like one.

Predisposed to experiencing difficulties yet behaving responsibly, children were repeatedly framed as participants in a world that did not cater to them.

In terms of the future, students possessed relatively clear-eyed, context-aware visions. For example, one morning Ms. Dawes led a game of "would you rather?" where students had to walk to either end of the classroom depending on their answer.

Ms. Dawes asks, "Would you rather be rich and live far away from your family, or be poor and live near them?" This question sparks a lot of debate and activity amongst the kids, as they ponder aloud, or move with certainty while making declarations. Overall, most of the kids elect to stay near their family and be poor, except for Louise and Sandra . . . [who] said pragmatically, "If you're rich you can fly back to see your family." In contrast, shaking her head as if the issue were non-negotiable, Ashante declared, "I love my family," while Rosario backed her up with a firm, "I'm staying!"

Akin to the collective obligations visible in relative identity, Brighton students placed

considerable value on family in their futures and were accepting of limitations to personal success.

Likewise, when asked more generally about the future, Brighton students had pragmatically optimistic hopes. For example, while waiting outside the nurse's office one day, I asked:

"What do you want to be when you're older?" José replies quickly, "A cop. My granddad used to be a cop so I want to be one. Either that or maybe the army, as my uncle used to be in that." He . . . smil[es] slightly . . . his tone suggesting these options are reasonable and obtainable. I turn to Courtney and she replies with confidence "a cook," then smiles bashfully.

Other answers commonly given, and repeated over the course of the year, were "teacher" and "nurse." The clarity with which these children saw their futures is in striking contrast to the vagueness of the Truman children and appears counterintuitive to cultural capital theory. However, they make sense in light of the future being presented as challenging, thereby requiring planning, which may still go awry. For example, while outside with Ms. Campen, surrounded by a group of her higher-achieving 4th-grade girls:

Ms. Campen then asks the girls, "What do you wanna be in the future?" Selena [one of the smartest students in the year] jumps in first, "Not a sociologist!" This causes Ms. Campen and myself to laugh. After a few seconds Ms. Campen replies sagely, "Yeah, you wanna make some money. What if you get divorced? You need an income." Selena then offers, "I wanna be a scientist and work with computers." Ms. Campen nods supportively, "Yeah, that's good." Sydney says, "I wanna be a pharmacist." Ms. Campen says eagerly, "Yeah!" and gives her a high five. Carmen says she wants to be a doctor, and Ms. Campen gives her a high five too.

In response to Ms. Campen warning 9-year-old girls about the instability of divorce, the

higher-achieving girls list especially ambitious, economically rewarding career goals. Only lengthy longitudinal work could ascertain whether these girls sustain or reach these occupational aspirations (for working-class college students' preference for stable jobs, see Silver 2020). But while this encouragement may be advantageous, it was not applied to all students, nor was success presented as something to be expected. Indeed, on another occasion, Ms. Campen described a group of poor White boys in her class as "future gang members" and, one lunchtime, complained, "I'm sick of it where now everyone thinks they're special. I don't like the whole 'everyone gets a trophy' thing. That's not what life is like!" These feelings were conveyed particularly strongly to poor students and Black students, as I show below. In general, Brighton students were taught to see themselves as participants journeying through an unyielding world, to expect external challenges, and to hope for advancements in the future.

Internal Variations: Truman

Overall, Truman children were taught that thanks to their internal qualities they are always-already special, whereas Brighton children were taught they are conditionally good, provided they abide by external rules. Nevertheless, there were variations in this messaging at each school. At Truman, variations were visible in which students were considered to sufficiently adopt this social station (i.e., being special), and which teachers supported this socialization. At Brighton, variation was more overtly discriminatory and involved how harshly teachers judged certain students and therefore what conditions they had to meet to be considered "good."

Starting with Truman students' variation, teachers expected students to absorb and enact the lessons they received. Students needed to demonstrate belief in their unique identities, inherent worth, and agency over their surroundings and prospects. Two ways of demonstrating this were sharing opinions and being vocal. Teachers worried about students

who were quiet, did not like sharing their views and presenting their work, or appeared diffident. For instance, while hiking at a local nature reserve, I observed the following interaction, where Ms. Daniels exhorts Florence, a tall, skinny, pale White 5th-grader, to be more powerful, direct, and agentic:

As they continued trudging up a hill, Ms. Daniels, in a supportive, encouraging voice says, "So Florence, from the time we've spent together . . . you're always walking around like this." Ms. Daniels waves her wrist around slowly and airily, gently wagging her fingers. "You go through life like the wind blows you around." Florence looks at Ms. Daniels's gesture and gives a slight smile. Ms. Daniels continues, "But if you go around like this, how are you going to have power? Do you know what I mean by that? [Florence makes a slight nod.] How are you going to be a chooser? You wanna choose things, right? [Florence gives a slightly stronger nod.] Yeah, so you want to try and be a bit stronger, a bit more direct. Ok?" Ms. Daniels clenches her right fist and moves it forward in a "go get 'em" gesture. She smiles in a friendly, supportive way and Florence, a tad uncertainly, smiles back.

Such additional, focused forms of socialization were overwhelmingly aimed at Truman girls. Indeed, in her interview Ms. Daniels stated that "[t]here are no boys that whisper. It's not a thing. It doesn't exist. Every year, we saw at least one girl who came to our class and answered everything in a whisper. That is crazy!"

However, teachers disproportionately noted and devoted extra socialization toward Asian American girls. For example, Ms. Lacey, who ran a weekly Girls' Math Club during recess stated in her interview:

A lot of the girls who actually are in here like Jill and Geeta, very quiet, won't ask for anything, will just try and get it done and kind of fly under the radar and follow the rules. . . . I think a lot of them use [the

Girls' Math Club] as an opportunity to be social with one another. Kids who are not embedded in the social culture of Truman. So [Girls' Math Club] is a small environment that they can see their friends and do something where it feels a little bit more controlled and a little bit more safe.

Jill and Geeta, both Asian American girls, were highlighted by Ms. Lacey as quiet and passive. In this way, they do not fit the "culture" of Truman. Other teachers similarly highlighted Asian American girls in their interviews as "timid" and "quiet."

Addressing this perceived problem, teachers would recommend solutions, such as the following advice for Asian American 4th-grader, Ava:

Ms. Daniels says encouragingly, "So I know you have a soft voice and it's hard for you to overcome that, but we need to think of some ways for you to be able to get everyone's attention so that you can give them instructions. So one way, maybe, could be that you add something to your voice, like touching them or big eye contact. [Ms. Daniels mimes this as she says it, grasping Ava's arm and widening her eyes.] Another option could be shouting a bit louder, like calling 'STOP!' and then speaking normally again." Mr. Ryan interjects, "Yeah, that could work." Ava chews her lip in thought.

In encouraging girls, particularly Asian American girls, to demonstrate their special social station, Truman teachers can be seen as pursuing feminist goals. But these findings also raise issues of obliging students to enact the institution's dominant norms of behavior. Others have described the hazards of molding Black and Latinx students to fit the behavioral norms of predominantly White, often elite, spaces (Cartwright 2022; Cox 2016), but less attention has been devoted to the experiences of Asian Americans (see Kao 2000; Lee and Zhou 2015).

A second variation at Truman involved teachers' attachment to always-already special

messaging. Most staff at Truman were from intergenerationally stable middle-class backgrounds. But a small minority had working-class roots. In general, the former held senior positions or were homeroom teachers (who had the most sustained contact with students), and the latter were more commonly substitutes, specialists, or in lower administration (e.g., P.E., language teachers, receptionists). These upwardly mobile employees were less supportive of Truman's socialization norms. For example, the P.E. teacher discussed above lamented that Truman students "just aren't used to competing and losing, and they don't know how to deal with it." Likewise, an upwardly mobile staff member explained:

If I could change one thing [at Truman], I think I would like to change the entitlement. There is a lot of entitlement. . . . I don't feel that kids [at Truman] learn to be responsible. . . . I have kids say, "My mom forgot this and my mom forgot that." No, you forgot it, you left it at home!

Similarly, another staff member described how students would fake illnesses, such as stomach pains, to get out of trouble—something I also witnessed—and that when she resisted these attempts, "Kids [at Truman] are very surprised that not everything leads to a reaction the way they imagined it might." She went on to describe how Truman "reeks of entitlement." Thus, upwardly mobile staff members used the language of entitlement to criticize Truman practices. They saw the school as too indulgent, thereby encouraging problematic attitudes and behaviors.

Stably middle-class staff members were overwhelmingly supportive of Truman's approach. On rare occasions—when these teachers were already very annoyed (see Calarco 2018) or when they perceived students as being actively resistant (see McFarland 2001)—they would speak of entitlement, usually in relation to an individual rather than all students. But these moments did not deter them from socializing children to believe in their always-already special social station.

Internal Variations: Brighton

At Brighton, cultural messaging varied minimally by teacher—likely due to almost all teachers being upwardly mobile White women—but significantly by students' background, specifically their race and class. The logic that children were conditionally good was dominant throughout the school. But for some students, particularly poor students and Black students, teachers were less likely to perceive and treat them as "good." Whereas Truman's Asian American girls received supplementary socialization intended to be supportive, variations at Brighton were more directly discriminatory.

The discrepant perception and treatment of Brighton students was visible in the behavioral standards demanded. Laya, a White girl from a poor family, and Rita, a lower-middle-class White girl, were petite and tended to kneel on their chairs to better look down on their desks. They were routinely reprimanded for this but in strikingly different ways. For instance, Laya was ordered, "Laya, that's not how we sit! Sit on your bottom." In contrast, Rita was told, "Rita, don't sit like that, hon. I don't want you to fall off and hurt yourself." Poor students and Black students generally received sanctions that were sharper or more severe, as visible in this example with Ashante, a working-class Black student:

While Ashante is out at the bathroom, Ms. Collins says to me, "While she is out, Mr. Peter, can you pick up all her tickets and put them on your table for me?" Surprised, but [feeling I had] no other option, I start doing this. Ashante comes back in as I'm almost done and I breathe "Sorry!" to her twice, hoping she knows I don't want to do this. Ashante shrugs. Ms. Collins tells her, "Mr. Peter is taking all your tickets as you were playing with them when you weren't supposed to." There are about 200 tickets, given for good behavior, that I'm taking for a single indiscretion.²¹

Ordinarily, moving someone's stick down the behavioral chart cost them two tickets, so taking

away a student's entire collection—the only occasion I witnessed this—was an extremely disproportionate punishment. At other times when students counted tickets out of turn, they were simply verbally reprimanded.

Although Ashante's tickets were eventually returned, encounters such as these for Ashante and Laya conveyed that minor discrepancies warranted heavy discipline and that it was difficult for them to be considered "good." Indeed, teachers would discuss students at lunchtime and develop narratives around them, which appeared to reinforce the disproportionately negative experiences of poor and Black students (see Freidus 2020). For example, Alan, a White working-class boy was repeatedly described by teachers as "just a really good kid." In contrast, despite being a member of Brighton's gifted program, Ashante was described by teachers as "thinking she's hot shit" and her membership in the program was queried as being simply "because she's Black." This discriminatory treatment seemed to affect Ashante. Sometimes she would dismiss sanctions by muttering "I don't care." But on other occasions she seemed more affected. For instance, after a run of harsh treatment from Ms. Collins, including being yelled at that morning for not trying hard enough in P.E., Ashante broke down unexpectedly after a minor reprimand from the library teacher Ms. Daltry:

"Go to the back of the line, Ashante. Go on." Ashante goes, and as the others file out, Ashante suddenly bursts into tears. Ms. Daltry tells her kindly there's no need to cry, but Ashante sobs, "I did the worst thing ever!" Ms. Daltry looks baffled.

Poor students and Black students at Brighton were regularly evaluated more harshly by teachers. They received, and seemingly absorbed, lessons that they were prone to being bad, or were usually less good, than their peers.²²

Lastly, while both schools were largely class-homogeneous, the students from discrepant class backgrounds provide some useful insights. Working-class Truman students

who had spent many years at the school appeared to absorb and reflect feeling always-already special. It is unclear whether this persisted at home. But newer working-class arrivals at Truman were often quieter and less willing to share work publicly, but also happier to collaborate. I observed teachers flood these newer students with positive feedback in their early days at the school, which appeared to successfully encourage them over several weeks to be more academically demonstrative (e.g., volunteering to read aloud). At Brighton, middle-class students showed some features of a special social station, such as trying to deviate slightly from instructions or occupy the limelight for longer during group shares; for some children, this was maintained due to Brighton teachers' reluctance to sanction students with powerful parents (see Calarco 2020). Yet, middle-class Brighton students' markers of their social station never reached the same levels as Truman students in terms of elaborately constructed identity projects, trouble collaborating, refusal to accept losing, or vague nonchalance about their futures. This suggests some lessons about social station are taught at home, but schools expand and intensify these lessons.

DISCUSSION

In explaining social reproduction, sociologists have highlighted many elements of childhood inequality, including unequal resources, different skills and dispositions, and race and gender discrimination. However, the implications of these inequalities for what children are taught about their position and direction in the world—their social station—has not always been examined so assiduously. This is despite strong evidence that self-perceptions are important for actions, outcomes, and social reproduction, therefore warranting further attention (Lamont 2019). To be sure, recent studies have explored children's position relative to peers along specific lines, such as consumption (Musto 2019; Pugh 2009; Tyson 2011), and classic works focus on what children are taught about their

direction, specifically their class trajectories (Bowles and Gintis 1976; MacLeod 2009; Willis 1977). Psychological and anthropological work, although focused on class variations, further suggests that children are taught to have different “selves” or “individualisms” (Kraus et al. 2012; Kusserow 2004; Stephens et al. 2014). The most detailed (and intersectional) accounts of social station socialization come from a handful of school case studies (Bettie 2014; Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Golann 2021; Khan 2010). Each finds meritocratic underpinnings to these social station lessons: elite boarding schoolers learn they are at the top because of purported hard work and ongoing achievement (Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010), and students in resource-poor schools are taught that low self-worth and limited prospects stem from their own failures (Bettie 2014; Golann 2021).

Overall, I found that students at Truman Academy, the upper-middle-class private school, and Brighton Elementary, the working-class public school, were ascribed markedly different social stations, neither of which were predicated on achievement narratives. Truman students were taught to see themselves as always-already special due to their internal qualities; they are unique, inherently worthy, and agentic with bright futures. Their current position is buoyant, their prospects bubbling away in the distance, confident they are floating upstream. Conversely, Brighton students were taught to see themselves as conditionally good provided they adhered to external rules; they are individuals with collective obligations, contingently worthy, and participants in a challenging world. Rather than floating upstream, Brighton children's ascribed position is weighted, their futures dependent on how they navigate inevitable upcoming waves.

The discrepancy between my findings and the literature is pertinent to scholars of culture and race. Rather than emphasize what they do or achieve (Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010), Truman students were taught to emphasize *who they are*. This was not a return to previous narratives emphasizing inheritance

and connections, however, but appears to be an incorporation of identity rhetoric into prevailing patterns of classed distinction. Thus, Truman students were taught to be more individualistic than their Brighton peers. And notions of racial/ethnic identity were utilized *in pursuit of* this individualism. Others have highlighted how diversity can be repurposed to benefit already privileged groups (Fish 2019; Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Warikoo 2016). This could represent a modulation of systems of evaluation, wherein identity is (becoming) a resource, either as a feature of cultural capital or as an internal basis for one's sense of self. Akin to shifts toward omnivorousness that require fluency not just in opera but in basketball too (Khan 2010; Peterson and Kern 1996), the ability to talk about one's identities may be a new marker of distinction. My findings, and the historic nimbleness of the middle-classes in adapting to changing systems of evaluation (Bourdieu 1998), suggest that upper-middle-class children are primed to exploit such a modulation. Brighton socialization is comparatively out of step; what Bourdieu (1984) calls "hysteresis." Marginalized students at Brighton—who would benefit most from identity-based social stations (see Godfrey, Santos, and Burton 2019)—are socialized otherwise; their White, upwardly mobile teachers are hostile to discussions of race, identity, or structural inequalities. As at Truman, Brighton teachers did not emphasize meritocratic achievement when teaching children their social station. However, similar to others' findings (Golann 2021; Kusserow 2004), discipline and collective obligations were prominent.

Of course, the relative absence of meritocratic achievement narratives in the social station socialization I observed could be products of institutional idiosyncrasies or students' age. I cannot rule out the former, although interviewed substitute teachers recounted similar practices at parallel schools where they had taught, and Truman and Brighton were less elite and less deprived, respectively, than schools studied by others (e.g., Golann 2021; Khan 2010). As for age, it may well

be that meritocratic narratives of achievement become more prominent in social station socialization as children enter middle or high school. But scholars argue that fundamental, long-lasting lessons are absorbed when we are young (e.g., Bourdieu 1990). If early social station socialization emphasizes being always-already special due to inherent qualities or conditionally good given adherence to external rules, then narratives about hard work and achievement may remain a supplementary disparity in how children and adults perceive their position and direction in the world.

Another implication of these findings relevant for sociologists of education and culture is the importance of schools as sites of socialization. Schools have often been recognized as unequal institutions (Anyon 1980; Lewis and Diamond 2015). But regarding socialization, schools are regularly positioned as "neutral" or "static" arenas to which differently rewarded forms of culture are brought from home (Ispa-Landa 2015; see Bourdieu and Passeron 1990). Alongside others (e.g., Musto 2019; Tyson 2011), I emphasize how schools convey many cultural lessons. Some of this aligns with parental socialization (which is beyond the scope of this article). But school-based studies are crucial for highlighting factors invisible in family-based studies. For one, racial discrimination within socialization can be seen. I highlight the supplementary socialization Asian American girls at Truman were deemed to need and the sharply discriminatory, harsher treatment endured by Brighton's poor students and Black students. A second variation highlighted by school observations are differences in cultural socialization that align with teachers' class backgrounds. This is insufficiently discussed, as teachers are often presumed to support dominant middle-class norms (Bourdieu and Passeron 1990; but see Harvey 2022). Yet I show that Truman staff from working-class backgrounds criticized cultivating a special social station and thereby encouraging entitlement among students. Like the similarly upwardly mobile teachers at Brighton, they did not believe everyone "deserves a trophy."

More broadly, the individualism encouraged as part of being always-already special carries implications across various domains relevant for inequality and social reproduction. Truman students appeared to struggle when their preferences were not met, when obliged to work with others, and when they lost out in competitions. It is possible that students mature out of these tendencies. But research demonstrates a sharp rise in highly individualistic, troubling trends associated with young, upper-middle-class adults shaped by neoliberal logics and institutions (Côté et al. 2020; Lamont 2019; Twenge 2014). For instance, social psychologists are devoting increasing attention to “academic entitlement,” where students feel deserving of top grades regardless of effort (Greenberger et al. 2008; Jiang, Tripp, and Hong 2017). Sociological work in this area finds, across racial groups, disparities between working- and upper-middle-class college students’ willingness to pressure institutional agents, which leads to a range of unfair advantages for the latter (Ferguson 2021). While this suggests a clear benefit for upper-middle-class students, others have highlighted spiraling rates of mental health issues among the young, including high-achieving students and those from wealthy backgrounds (American Psychological Association 2018; Parodi et al. 2022). And scholars have also found increasingly strong links between individualism and resistance to vaccinations, including Covid-19 (Chen, Frey, and Presidente 2021; Estep and Greenberg 2020). Thus, growing individualism in adults related to that taught at Truman is having significant effects on fields of education, mental well-being, and public health. Brighton students’ greater pragmatism and appetite for collective obligations may carry certain societal-level advantages, but often at the cost of working-class children’s own trajectories (Illouz 2019). Thus, how children are taught to see their social station seems to resonate in complicated ways well beyond the schoolyard.

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Notes

1. Historically, station meant “your position in society” (*Macmillan Dictionary* 2022). It was largely static and based on one’s social class. In this article, I use station more broadly and dynamically. “Narratives,” “scripts of the self,” “self-concept” and other terms have been used to touch on aspects of social station (Lamont 2019; Takacs 2020; Tyson 2011). But they can inadvertently imply that people internally recite an explicit script of the self, which they will then regurgitate (e.g., “I am special.”). As I will show, this is not necessarily the case. “Identity” also encompasses aspects of social station (Burke and Stets 2009; Stryker 1980), but its wide usage can render the term blurry. Moreover, identity can sound entirely ego-centric, such that its structural underpinning is overlooked. Hence, my preference for social station.
2. Bettie (2014) describes her school site as rural and working-class, but notes that approximately 60 percent of the students were from families below the poverty line, and many of the girls she studied experienced considerable precarity.
3. All names are pseudonyms.
4. Lareau’s (2011) influential observation that middle-class children learn a sense of “entitlement,” whereas working-class and poor children learn a sense of “constraint,” captures children’s classed dispositions. But dispositions—tendencies to think and act in patterned ways (Bourdieu 1990; Reay 2004)—are distinct from how people see themselves, their position, and their direction in the world, which Lareau does not directly take up. Acting entitled is likely built on, but not the same as, one’s sense of individualism, superiority, and potency. Thus, seeing oneself as always-already special is different from, although undoubtedly connected to, acting entitled. Lareau also focuses more on parents and the childrearing process and less on school socialization experiences.
5. Hagerman (2018) does not examine the socialization processes involved or how other children might see themselves differently.
6. These studies sometimes talk about children’s sense of their “position,” but primarily to mean children’s class trajectory.
7. After trying for 18 months to access a city school, I turned to the bordering district containing Brighton.

8. Three parents were also staff members.
9. I am vague on specifics to protect confidentiality.
10. Middle-class families have at least one parent with a four-year degree, a white-collar job, and household income of approximately \$80,000 to \$120,000. Lower-middle-class families, by contrast, typically have a parent with some college and a household income of approximately \$60,000 to \$80,000.
11. "Always-already" has philosophical roots (Althusser 1971) but has been used by childhood scholars to emphasize children's inherent agency (Bettie 2014; Streib 2011). I use it to illuminate differences in social station socialization, including variations in ascribed agency.
12. Scholars have used "special" and "good" in relation to childhood socialization, although typically in passing (Gansen 2021; Gaztambide-Fernández 2009; Khan 2010; Lewis 2003). Hagerman (2018) and Freidus (2020) provide the most in-depth analyses of "specialness" and "goodness," respectively, but neither break down the components of these self-perceptions.
13. I prefer relative identity, moral worth, and situated prospects to individuality, self-esteem, and self-efficacy, as they are more socially and structurally oriented, and better reflect how children are taught to see themselves.
14. This does not mean teachers at Truman (and Brighton) did not care about learning and achievement. It just means that lessons about children's relative identity, and social station more broadly, were not predicated on achievement.
15. The Pledge of Allegiance was not recited at Truman.
16. During one lesson where a worksheet, unusually, asked Brighton students to write "What makes you special?" their answers were short and did not primarily differentiate (e.g., "I am very nice," "I have freckles"). In contrast, during one of many lessons on identity at Truman, students were assigned the prompt, "Even though people think they understand who I am, they may not realize that I am . . ." Each child wrote several lines (e.g., "I am sure that I am strong, athletic, hard-core, girlie, nice, kind to all, energetic, funny, pretty, cute, sweet, caring, bossy, sassy, stubborn [sic], love animals, short temperd [sic], always hungry, ache, flexible, jumpy, hates to be excluded, understanding, apollogetic [sic], loving, kind and a winner and sometimes a tiny bit aggressive"). Truman students did not simply self-describe as "special" but favored extensive elaborations on how they were unique.
17. Brighton teachers allowed some students to skip their turn during academic presentations, but those requesting skips almost exclusively struggled academically and, typically, were working-class or poor. In these cases, teachers seemed to prioritize saving students from embarrassment. When skipping was interpreted as an attempt to garner attention—as with Louise, and which almost exclusively

was attempted by middle-class students—it was denied. Truman students, by contrast, were taught to see presentations as legitimate opportunities to receive attention.

18. The school did not maintain a list of infractions with predetermined penalties, as found in "no excuses" schools (Golann 2021).
19. To protect school anonymity, the specific wording of their mottos has been tweaked, but the meaning and tone are as comparable as possible.
20. This aligns with Nelson's (2010:46) finding that upper-middle-class parents "simultaneously have higher and more amorphous expectations" for their children's futures than do working-class parents. See also Binder, Davis, and Bloom (2016) for how elite college students reject "ordinary" jobs.
21. I worked hard to have a non-authoritative role at the schools and to resist being seen by students as on the teachers' side. Because an ethnographer's access to a site is often precarious, I had to weigh, in this instant, whether to resist Ms. Collins's instruction and risk angering her and perhaps even expulsion from the school, or comply. I opted to reluctantly comply. Although I worried extensively about the repercussions of this incident, my relationship with Ashante did not seem to suffer.
22. Further examination of race and class discrimination is beyond the scope of this article, but I examine it extensively elsewhere.

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